

Don't Peddle Flawed Research – AI and the Environment

Posted by u/Please-I-Need-It • 0 points • 68 comments

There's been this bizarre study that's been peddled around from Scientific Reports. On Reddit, it's recognizable by a distinct black and white bar graph located in the study that shows up as a preview image.

For what it is, it's a questionable study with bizarre... everything, from the fact that [the human does not stop producing carbon even when not writing something (making AI carbon production an add-on to the human carbon footprint and not an alternative)] (<https://www.reddit.com/r/singularity/s/zXNwvHhmfE>), to [the way the carbon footprint of a human is calculated](<https://www.reddit.com/r/singularity/s/cIY3x4oBMZ>), [to how ChatGPT's carbon footprint per query is sourced from a Medium article, to how the paper assumes you need one (1) ChatGPT query to get a satisfactory result] (<https://www.reddit.com/r/singularity/s/JlyENSr8hJ>), to even how [the paper it's been published in is has published plenty of obvious bullshit before] (<https://www.reddit.com/r/aiwars/s/cLP0t8RDYL>). At best, this is rough back of the napkin math that is ****not a reliable study in the slightest****, and more rigorous studies need to be done to verify its conclusion.

Yet, here on the AI Wars subreddit, people peddle this around like an anti-AI “gotcha” because Nature itself is a prestigious journal (not considering it's from Scientific Reports and not the “main” journal) and “the science can't be wrong, right?”

Looking outside of this one study/one subreddit and just looking for AI emissions in general, you find some pretty alarming news. [Tech giants Google and Microsoft's emissions ballooned with the rise of Generative AI](<https://www.npr.org/2024/07/12/g-s1-9545/ai-brings-soaring-emissions-for-google-and-microsoft-a-major-contributor-to-climate-change>). The big detail to note is the 48% in Google emissions in 5 years. [This] (<https://news.mit.edu/2025/explained-generative-ai-environmental-impact-0117>) is a pretty good breakdown of all facets of Generative AI, touching on training, water usage, carbon output, and even everyday use of the AI (yes, it's not just training; one query on ChatGPT is comparable to 10 queries on Google search). Big tech promises of zero emissions look increasingly shaky, and in a technological arms race, new model after new model is being trained, adding to the environmental disaster.

So, this is bad. How will the sub react?

Um, um, gaming uses electricity! Also, using a computer! That uses electricity! Using social media uses electricity! Using-

I'm going to cut that off. I don't know why people are so stuck on hypothetical comparisons to Thing A or Thing B. Thing A being equally bad does not justify Generative AI's existence, period. People are so eager to "do the math" themselves and point out numbers when the actually reliable, peer reviewed consensus is that AI is plain bad for the environment, simple.

The thing is, even if YOU aren't producing that much carbon individually, you are a supporter of or indulging in the waste that is collectively dooming the environment, and that is a choice. You can watch as your peers ransack the environment for technological progress, contributing to it crumb by crumb... or you can step back, let go of the technology and therefore forfeit the support for an industry that only pays lip service to saving the world.

Comments

[u/donniebaker1](#) • 1 points • 2025-05-06 17:27 UTC

Talk talk and no evidence of what the final results will be of removing all carbon dioxide .. you can learn this if you take a course in botany ...

by the time to find out the truth will be too late and your life will be very short lived... Don't take my opinion learn yourself...

[u/crapsh0ot](#) • 1 points • 2025-01-27 23:41 UTC

Your point about peddling flawed research is valid, but at the end of the day you just had to say this:

\> I'm going to cut that off. I don't know why people are so stuck on hypothetical comparisons to Thing A or Thing B. Thing A being equally bad does not justify Generative AI's existence, period.

So are you **agreeing** that video games is just as bad as AI? I thought the claim was that AI is **worse** for the environment than video games. The point isn't that people complaining about AI for it's impact on environment aren't allowed to be mad because video games are just as bad. The point is that it's mega sus that they aren't **equally mad about video games**.

Conversely, if you really are claiming AI is worse from purely an environmental impact perspective, then "oh but its existence would still be unjustified if the energy use was the same" can only undermine your point.

... apologies, I'm strawmanning you, aren't I? Your real argument is this:

\> The thing is, even if YOU aren't producing that much carbon individually, you are a supporter of or indulging in the waste that is collectively dooming the environment, and that is a choice.

So basically, if I run an AI image generator locally and see with my own two eyes that generating a few images, then picking the one closest to my vision to touch up in medibang decreases my laptop's battery % less than drawing the thing from scratch, it still doesn't matter if the AI-assisted work process makes me personally use less power than if I used an AI-free one, because the people who made the model I was using are destroying the environment? Is that what you're saying?

I got it for free and didn't pay them a cent, so I dispute the claim that I'm "supporting" them. As for "indulging in", I'm also a dumpster diver who takes food from commercial dumpsters. I literally benefit from supermarkets' wasteful practices, so I'm afraid that argument isn't going to move me.

u/Please-I-Need-It • 2 points • 2025-01-28 02:47 UTC

You know what? Fair enough, this seems like a fair assessment even if we mutually disagree.

u/nyanpires • 2 points • 2025-01-27 16:43 UTC

Don't pretend AI is doing nothing, that's the point. Stop making excuses and cherry-picking data to make it look harmless. Admit that it IS harmful, CAN do bad. It's not the most amazing thing in the world. You can admit something does harm to the world and still use it, understand the guilt of being Environmentally Friendly: You can't fix everything.

That doesn't mean we ignore it.

u/MechaSharkEternal • 2 points • 2025-01-27 19:09 UTC

Thank you for this. As someone who both finds generative AI fascinating and spends a lot of time thinking about the environment and ways it is impacted by human development, it sucks to not see people fully acknowledging the harm it causes or having discussions about how to decrease that harm.

u/nyanpires • 2 points • 2025-01-27 20:16 UTC

Exactly. I MUST drive a car, I know it's the worst. What do I do? I do a lot offline to help (removing invasive species, helping out local evs related stuff). I also keep my lights off as long as possible. it's almost like climate change denial when you bring up the cost.